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things become easy. I played so many tournaments in India, so I knew pretty much everyone,” he says, adding with a smile, “Unfortunately, there was nobody from Pakistan to play with. So, playing with an Indian just came very naturally to me. I never thought about where they were from, what their religion was; it was just about playing the game and striving for success...”

While he enjoyed success in singles, the impact was not as significant as it was during his doubles partnership with Bopanna. “I wish the Indo-Pak Express lasted longer, but Bops had stronger line-ups. It was the Olympic year (2012), and they wanted to pair him with an Indian and give it their best shot, so it was not easy for me as I would have loved to continue. But then, that’s how the sport is,” he

says.

Even though the ‘Indo-Pak Express’ is a thing of the past, Qureshi remains in touch with his old friend. When the Indian bettered his own record as the oldest player to win an ATP Masters 1000 title after winning the 2024 Miami Open with Australia’s Matt Ebden, Qureshi and his parents congratulated him and spoke at length. “I cherish those memories with Bops and the friendship.”

As a youngster, Qureshi was involved in multiple sports, but when his mother took him to a tennis session during one of the summer breaks, little did he know that decades later, he would go on to become one of the icons of the game. And he rightly sums it up, saying: “I would not have been the person I am today if I didn’t have tennis in my life...”

FACTFILE



Serve-and-Volley Specialist

Qureshi is known for his classic serve-and-volley style, a rarity in modern tennis, which made him especially effective in doubles.



US Open Finalist (2010)

He reached the men’s doubles final at the 2010 US Open with Rohan Bopanna, famously as the Indo-Pak Express — a landmark moment for both countries.



Won 18 ATP Titles

Over his professional career, he won 18 ATP titles proving his consistency and longevity on the tour.



Entered Top 10 in Doubles

Achieved his highest ranking of 8 in doubles in the year 2011.



Promoter of Indo-Pak Peace

Through his partnership with Bopanna, Qureshi launched the campaign ‘Stop War, Start Tennis’, using sport to promote peace between their countries.



Humanitarian Work and UN Goodwill Ambassador

Beyond the court, he’s been involved in humanitarian efforts and was once a UNDP Goodwill Ambassador for peace and development.



Tokens of Appreciation

Received the President’s Award for Performance by the Government of Pakistan in 2004, and the Arthur Ashe Humanitarian of the Year Award in 2002 and 2010.